

The 10-minute deck safety inspection.

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Ten minutes with a flashlight and a screwdriver will tell you more than any sales visit. This is the same sequence we run on every structural inspection, in order of what actually fails. Walk your deck with this sheet and you'll know whether you're looking at nothing, a repair, or a real problem — before anyone quotes you a dollar.

01 The ledger (where the deck meets the house)

What to check: from underneath, find the horizontal board bolted against the house. Look for metal flashing over its top edge, real bolts or structural screws (not just nails), and dry, solid wood.

When to worry: no visible flashing, rust streaks, soft or dark wet wood, or a ledger attached with nails alone. This is where most catastrophic deck collapses start — anything suspicious here is a call-a-pro finding.

02 Footings and posts

What to check: posts should sit on concrete footings via metal brackets — not buried in dirt, not resting on patio blocks. Sight down each post for lean; look at footing tops for cracking or heaving.

When to worry: posts in ground contact (they rot from the bottom, invisibly), a footing lifted or tilted by frost, or daylight between post and bracket. Frost heave is Colorado's signature deck disease.

03 Joists and framing

What to check: underneath, probe a few joists with a screwdriver — especially near the ledger and any stains. Solid wood resists; rot gives. Joist hangers should have nails in every hole and no orange rust bloom.

When to worry: a screwdriver that sinks in easily anywhere, hangers missing fasteners, or joists pulling away from the ledger. Blackened wood that's still hard is usually cosmetic; soft wood never is.

04 Railings and posts

What to check: grab the top rail and push hard, at several points. It should feel like part of the structure, not furniture. Balusters tight, spacing under 4 inches.

When to worry: any visible movement at the post base. A railing that wobbles today fails the day someone actually falls against it — post connections are the most common failure we find on older and DIY decks.

05 Stairs

What to check: walk them heavily. Check the stringers where they meet the deck and the ground, the tread fasteners, and the handrail's steadiness.

When to worry: bounce or flex mid-flight, stringers resting on bare dirt, treads cupped enough to hold water, or a handrail you wouldn't trust with your full weight. Stairs are where most deck injuries happen.

06 The surface

What to check: scan for cupped, split, or spongy boards, popped fasteners, and gaps that have closed up. Note whether wear is cosmetic — graying, checking — or structural.

When to worry: soft spots underfoot mean the problem is below the boards, not in them. Widespread splitting on a 20+ year old wood deck usually means the surface is done even if the frame is sound — which is what re-decking is for.

Scoring it

- **Surface wear only, structure checks out:** restore or re-deck.
- **One or two isolated findings (a post, some boards):** targeted repair.
- **Ledger, footing, or framing findings:** professional inspection, now.
- **Multiple structural findings on a 20+ year deck:** likely replacement — and a re-deck over sound framing costs meaningfully less, which is why an honest verdict is worth real dollars.

When to run this

Once a year, ideally in spring — freeze-thaw does its damage over winter, and you want to find what moved before the deck's busiest season. Also when buying a house, and before any big party puts thirty people on a structure built for ten.

Found something — or not sure what you're looking at? Send us photos and we'll give you a straight answer, or book a free on-site structural inspection. If the bones are good, we'll be the first to tell you. 720-589-5680 · hakadecks.com/contact